Painting Fires

By Cole Sutterland

The speaker is at a craft fair with the paintings she has completed. Allow time for her to listen to customers before she responds to them. She gets lost in her own thoughts and voices them aloud as customers move away.

(to a customer) . . . . That is so nice of you. I get a little funny about my work, I guess, and, I don't know, flustered or something. Have you been a couple of blocks down the sidewalk? There's some amazing, really amazing painters here. No, I, mean. That's very sweet of you, but these are just pictures of my life. If I haven't seen it, I can't paint it. I remember hearing that old saying about "write what you know," and I'm a terrible writer, so I guess I just "paint what I know." There isn't anything very special about it.

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INTRODUCTION

It's a beautiful Saturday afternoon and our speaker has set up her art booth at a local craft fair. Her paintings are beautiful and reflect all aspects of her life.

It's been said that art reflects life . . . but what happens when the line between reality and fantasy becomes blurred? For most of us, daydreaming is a virtual world where we can rehearse the future, explore fearful scenarios or imagine new adventures without risk. For others, however, the draw of an alternative reality is an escape from a devastating reality – a coping mechanism that permits them to continue . . . Painting Fires by Cole Sutterland.

(to audience) This is, um, where my son and I go to find our Christmas tree every year. Sort of single mom, have to know how to use a saw. I never did a very good job, and I would always tell my son, "I guess that's what dads are for," and he would laugh. He always names the trees and then holds a little service to honor their passing when New Year's comes. I can't remember the tree's name that year. Or what my son got me. . . he always asks for the funniest things, though. Kids, you know. A book of maps. A new collar for his puppy. A tape recorder.

What kid asks for a tape recorder for Christmas? We don't have much, so . . . *(to a customer)* No, no, it's not sunset, there's just a bit of smoke or something on the horizon. Fire season. Oh, thank you so much. It's just a painting of our house. Blue and white. Small. Simple. But very happy. Like our lives, I guess you would say.

I'm so sorry. It's not for sale. No, I, I just can't. That's very generous of you, but it isn't finished yet. I'm sorry. That's of my son and his dog, Buddy. Big mutt. *(to audience)* My son was walking home from school one day and just like in the movies, Buddy followed him home. And he stayed. Right by Buddy's side. He does look sad there, I guess. He should be happy, warm by the fireplace, with his master. I guess, well, you see, we had been living with someone, we aren't, now, but we were then, and he didn't like Buddy barking. It annoyed him, he said. I stood my ground, though. And Buddy stayed. He stayed . . . forever. My son's father died when he was a baby and it was just the two of us for years.

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And we were very happy. I sang to my son every night before he went to sleep. His favorite was the one about the . . the . . . picnic . . . do you know that one? But then, when I met John, I thought that . . . I'm sorry, I'm rambling, I know, I just, I'm trying to explain about the painting of the house.

I met John and, at first, he did all of the right things. Flowers for me. Little league games with my son. And then, well, I guess sometimes things change so slowly that you don't even realize it until it's too late. And then you get stuck, I guess. Yeah, it's a forest fire. Nature's version of a do-over. The fire splits open the cones and they say that the trees grow back stronger and taller. But it takes a long time. So, I got stuck. John would come home from work and his nights were spent in front of the TV. He brought a permanent winter with him and we didn't really speak much anymore. It was like my son became an imposition, like a gnat that one might bat away out of annoyance. Angry words. Cold stares. I love my son very much. We didn't spend

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much time at home anymore. I brought that winter into our home and I let him stay. I'm sorry, I'm boring you, babbling on like this.

(to a customer) . . . I love that one too. Yeah, it's my son after the spelling bee. *(to audience)* We spent hours in the evenings, just the two of us, on long drives practicing for it. I've never seen a ten-year-old so dedicated to something. I couldn't believe it. Words that felt like they were thirty letters long and he would just go over and over them. He only missed one word, right at the end. I was so excited. I was holding my breath. I was just so proud of him though. I . . . I'm sorry, I don't remember the word exactly. It was . . . I don't even really remember what it meant, that word.

Oh, I would love for you to meet him too. That would be wonderful. No, I don't think he'll be able to come down tonight. I've been waiting, but. . . He's with Buddy, somewhere. No, no. I don't think I'm a very good mother at all. Oh. I don't know if I can finish the picture of the house tonight. I'm so

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sorry. I. . . well. I can't finish it because I still don't know how that story ends.

I guess, I didn't want us to be stuck anymore, you see. I was only going to be gone for just a little while. Just a bit. And, I . . . left my son and Buddy, they were watching TV in the living room and John, he was asleep on the couch, just like he always was. And I kissed my son on the top of his head and told him I'd be right back. Just right back. So, a little while later, my son, he calls me and he tells me that Buddy had started barking at John and well, John had told my son to "go upstairs right now and take the damn dog with you. And close your windows." And so, I told my son that it was okay, that everything was finally going to be okay and that he and Buddy just needed to wait upstairs and I would be home soon. And I just needed him to have everything ready. And he said, "I love you, Mom. I will." And then, you see, there was a line at the place and then, my credit card wouldn't work and it took longer than it should have, much longer. And by the

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time I got back and I turned up our street, you see, I couldn't even get close to our house, there were so many cars and . . .

I parked, and I ran, and I could see. I wanted to close my eyes and just pretend it away. But I could see. Just as I see it now. Fire is everywhere now. Great tongues of red and awful orange fingers. Like the fire was hungry, consuming our little blue and white house, turning it black, eating it. This was our summer. And I tried. I tried to walk in, because if I could just get in there, be there with him, hold him. I fought them so hard. But they wouldn't let me in. And so I screamed my son's name until all I could hear was the roaring.

Do you understand now? It needs red and orange to be finished. I can't finish it that way. They found my son upstairs, in the corner of his bedroom. He was holding Buddy.

The windows in his room were already too hot to touch. But Buddy was there, with my boy. Buddy

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stayed with him, with my little boy. After John sent them upstairs he, um, he lit a cigarette and then, he, he just fell asleep. And John, he walked out the front door and he took that cold winter with him. While my boy was upstairs. . . So I paint him and I keep him with me that way. All that we had and all that we'll never have. If I paint his high school graduation, then there he is, cap and gown, and I'm in the bleachers, cheering. I paint him on his wedding day. He looks so handsome. I . . . I just needed another thirty minutes and then we were going to go away. Sometimes I wonder if we did and this is just another place that I don't really understand. An in-between place.

I, I don't even know what I'm saying anymore. *(to a customer)* I'm sorry that painting isn't for sale, but thank you for all your kind words. *(to audience)* Maybe my son will stop by later. Maybe he'll bring Buddy. I wait, you see. I wait, and I wait and I wait. I'll wait forever until I get to see him again. But, for now, I keep a little piece of him with me until I get to

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see him again, you know? Until he shows up . . . After it happened, that thing I was talking about, I got to go and pick a few things up. Just a few. And, um, there was that tape recorder. The one I gave him for Christmas. And um, he'd recorded himself, and I listen to it now, anytime we're apart for a little while. I listen to it all the time, actually.

Hi Mom, it's me, your little monster. I thought it would be kind of cool to keep a record of stuff on here and maybe give it to you when I go away to college or something. So, today I wanted to say thank you for letting me keep Buddy. He says thanks for his neat blue collar. I know John hates him, but he's good to have around.

John was better today. I know you feel bad, Mom, but it's not that bad. But if we ever do want to go away, we can plan out places we could go with the maps.

You're better than a Mom and a Dad put together. Seriously. We'd be fine, I'd protect you.

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And that word I missed – it's palliate – it means, "to make a mistake better." I can spell it now.

And I know you said you wouldn't be able to sing to me anymore when I leave him, but that's not true. I'll call you and you can – you can sing, *"If you go out in the words today, you're sure of a big surprise. For every bear that ever there was will gather there for certain, because today's the day the teddy bears have their picnic."

Anyway, I love you Mom. Don't worry so much about me.

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AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

Music and Lyrics to the "Picnic Song" can be found at
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uxFIGWm9M6w

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